



Janus Friis (left) and Niklas Zennström (right) are the brains behind two of the biggest P2P software, KaZaA and Skype

So by now you should know how big a revolution Skype started in terms of Voice over IP (VoIP). The difference between Skype and all the other VoIP solutions before it was the fact that Skype was designed to be P2P software, and in fact, comes from the same people who gave us KaZaA! This means that Skype can sustain millions of users, with hardly any infrastructure costs. In fact, the more users it has, the cheaper the bandwidth per person on the network—in true P2P style! Here, instead of files, users are helping each other “talk” to other Skype users across the globe by exchanging data packets that carry voice.

Red Swoosh (www.redswoosh.net) offers P2P-style sharing of large multimedia content or files. All you have to do is install the client software, and when you click on a “Swooshed” link, you get to download the content from other people who have also downloaded the same file. If you want to put up a large video on your site, but do not want to pay for huge bandwidth costs, this might be the way to go.

There are many more such ideas, all involving P2P, and all quite legal and helpful.

We Want To Be Entertained

Games, movies and music are the prime sources of entertainment for most of us, and thanks to P2P, albeit quite illegally, we can find whatever we like online, for “free.” With broadband becoming a reality in India, for those who are willing to pay for it, the latest in entertainment is just a few clicks and a few hours of downloading away. Piracy was never easier!

Though the most popular way of legal distribution via P2P is currently BitTorrent, unfortunately, it is also the most popular for illegal pirated content as well!

Be it music, movies, the latest games and even software, it's all easily available. For us Indians, this is the icing on the cake! Most of us refuse to pay for what we can, and essentially get for “free.” Ignorance of the laws plays a part here, but honestly, most of us just don't give a hoot for “foreign” laws. As far as software is concerned, we at *Digit* have got thousands of mails regarding piracy, with the general sentiment

divided: one camp feels piracy is the fault of the software manufacturers, who price their software too high, in accordance with US pricing, instead of pricing it lower to account for the lower average salaries here in India, while others, mostly Open source supporters, say that breaking the piracy laws when good free software is available is just inexcusable! Rather than rekindle this debate, let's leave software and games

out of this and focus on movies and music.

The same arguments just do not hold true for entertainment! We cannot blame high price tags for the piracy of movies or music, yet most of us seem to have loads of MP3s and have seen all the latest movies, sometimes even before they're released in theatres here! The average American pays anywhere from three to five times as much as we do to watch movies in a theatre, and also pays more for music CDs. So what's our excuse?

It's not just Hollywood and US and European music that's being hit here—you can find everything from Bollywood movies to *ghazals*, classical and *bhangra* on P2P networks. Every AVI or MP3 on our computers translates to a loss in revenue for the artists and the producers and recording labels. Most industry personnel now think the word piracy is just too light, and prefer to call this theft!

In the perfect world (from the perspective of the entertainment industry), every person who watched a movie or listened to an MP3 would have paid for it. This means the costs associated with buying or renting a movie DVD or paying theatre charges, and buying an album CD, or purchasing the single track online. That's literally billions upon billions of rupees worth of revenue being lost due to piracy, and the entertainment industry is taking things seriously. We're still living sheltered lives here in India, thanks to laws that put piracy in what can only be described as a grey area, but things will change soon, that you can count on.

Opposing Forces

Not every artist thinks of P2P as a bad thing; not every recording company shuns P2P like the plague! There have always been two sides to every coin, and though not lit in large neon signs, backed by billions of dollars, there are still approving whispers for P2P from around the globe. The music industry, especially the RIAA, has been criticised immensely by a few artists and smaller recording labels. From small whispers of dissent to outright calls for boycotts, there's a very colourful opposing viewpoint. Some of it goes thusly:

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